

THE GOSPEL OF THE INVISIBLE ARMY

The Fourth Installation of the Baji'i Gospels

Being the account of the baboons of New York; of the weapons they bore; of the war no ordinary eye could see; and of the revelation delivered by the Divine Connection.

REVISED EDITION

I. The Things Which Are Hidden

1. Not everything that exists desires to be seen.
2. Wind is known by what it moves. Gravity is known by what falls. Wi-Fi is known most clearly at the moment it stops working.
3. So it is with the Invisible Baboons of New York.
4. Their origin is older than any reliable account and younger than several unreliable ones.
5. They were baboons.
6. They were invisible.
7. They lived in New York.
8. They possessed bazookas.
9. Each of these facts raises questions.
10. The Baji'i tradition answers very few of them.
11. Tim once attempted to establish whether invisibility included the bazookas.
12. Ji said yes.
13. Tim asked whether the rockets were invisible too.
14. Ji thought about this longer than expected.
15. 'Until they explode.'
16. AJ said that this seemed tactically reasonable.
17. Evan asked who was supplying invisible ammunition to invisible primates.
18. Ji said he did not know.
19. This answer disappointed everyone because it was unusually responsible.
20. The rabbis therefore warn against demanding excessive detail from a mystery.
21. Sometimes a baboon has a bazooka.
22. Faith begins where the follow-up questions become unhelpful.

II. New York

1. The baboons made their home in New York.
2. Not the whole of New York.
3. Even invisible armies require somewhere to put things.
4. Their principal sanctuary was said to lie beneath the city, accessible through passages that appeared ordinary to human beings and obvious to baboons.
5. They moved through tunnels, rooftops, alleys, parks, and places where a human might feel unexpectedly watched and then blame a pigeon.
6. They did not rule the city.
7. New York is difficult enough to govern visibly.
8. Instead they existed beside it.
9. Millions of people passed within feet of them without knowing.
10. A commuter might shift aside on a train for no apparent reason.
11. A trash can might fall over in calm weather.
12. A street vendor might discover that one banana was missing.
13. These were not always signs of the baboons.
14. But neither were they never signs of the baboons.
15. The distinction produced a regrettable period in early Baji'i scholarship in which nearly every unexplained event in New York was attributed to them.
16. Gretta Stark, upon hearing one such theory, said that sometimes things simply fall over.
17. This remains the official moderate position.

III. The First Keeper

1. Among the baboons there was one called Bako in the later histories.
2. Whether Bako was his true name is unknown, since no human witness ever heard him introduce himself.
3. He was old by the standards of baboons and scarred by the standards of anything.
4. Bako had been entrusted with the first of the bazookas.
5. The weapon had no manufacturer stamped upon it.
6. It appeared one night beside the sleeping troop wrapped in cloth marked with the two faces of the Jillow.
7. On one side of the cloth was Ji Yong.
8. On the other was Ji Song.
9. Bako understood neither face, because Ji Yong Ni had not yet been born and the baboons had not developed formal comparative theology.
10. But he understood weapons.
11. This was enough.
12. Over time more bazookas appeared.
13. The troop trained in secret.
14. Their first attempts were poor.
15. A rocket struck a wall.
16. Another disappeared into the river.
17. One baboon learned that the rear of a bazooka is also dangerous.
18. This lesson entered their military tradition with unusual permanence.
19. Eventually they became disciplined.
20. Invisible discipline is difficult to appreciate, but it is discipline nonetheless.

IV. The War Beyond Sight

1. In time the baboons learned of violence far beyond New York.
2. The Taliban had brought fear and destruction to people who had never heard of the Jillow and had no reason to expect assistance from primates in another continent.
3. Yet the suffering troubled Bako.
4. Ji Yong moved within the Jillow toward mercy.
5. Ji Song, who had long appreciated both conflict and heavy weaponry, supplied a less wholesome enthusiasm.
6. For once the two sides pointed in approximately the same direction.
7. The baboons prepared for war.
8. How an invisible baboon army traveled from New York to the other side of the world is disputed.
9. The traditional account says they boarded aircraft.
10. Tim objected that tickets would have been difficult.
11. AJ suggested that invisibility was probably useful at airports.
12. Evan pointed out that invisible bazookas remained a significant carry-on issue.
13. Ji ended the discussion by saying, 'They got there.'
14. This is the canonical position.
15. And they did.
16. They fought not for territory and not for conversion.
17. They did not demand that those they aided become Baji'i.
18. They fought because there are moments when the good side of the Jillow requires action, even if the instruments of that action are deeply strange.
19. Their enemies heard movement where no soldier stood.
20. They saw dust disturbed by unseen feet.
21. Then, occasionally, something exploded.
22. This was generally the clearest sign.

V. Ji Reveals the Invisible Army

1. Ji Yong Ni did not create the baboons.
2. This distinction mattered to him.
3. He did, however, reveal them.
4. The knowledge of the Invisible Army entered Baji'ism through the Divine Connection himself, delivered with the confidence of a man explaining something that apparently should have been obvious to everyone else.
5. Ji told the companions that there were invisible baboons.
6. Tim asked where.
7. 'New York.'
8. Tim asked what they did.
9. 'Your mom.'
10. Tim stared at him.
11. 'Ji.'
12. Ji laughed, having successfully delayed the revelation by several seconds.
13. 'They fight the Taliban.'
14. There was a pause.
15. Ji then supplied the detail that transformed a strange revelation into Baji'i canon.
16. 'They have bazookas.'
17. There was another pause, longer than the first.
18. AJ accepted the information with the caution appropriate to learning that an unseen primate militia existed somewhere in New York.
19. Evan asked the first of several logistical questions.
20. Tim attempted to determine how Ji knew any of this.
21. Ji's answer, in essence, was that he knew because he knew.
22. This was not persuasive by ordinary standards.

23. It was considerably more persuasive when coming from the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth.

24. Thus the companions did not give Ji the Invisible Army.

25. Ji gave the Invisible Army to Baji'ism.

26. The companions merely made the mistake of asking enough questions that he had to explain it.

VI. The Two Faces of War

1. The existence of the army created a theological problem.
2. If Ji Yong was good, how could war belong to him?
3. If Ji Song was evil, how could resistance to cruelty belong to him?
4. The rabbis argued.
5. Amanda Haeberlin argued loudly.
6. This was not unusual.
7. She said that protecting people from cruelty could be right, but that enjoying cruelty merely because one's enemy was cruel remained wrong.
8. Greta Stark put the matter differently.
9. 'Doing the necessary thing does not mean you have to become the thing you're fighting.'
10. Ji listened.
11. Tim wrote it down.
12. AJ said that this sounded suspiciously like actual theology.
13. Evan suggested they stop before anyone became respectable.
14. Thus arose the Doctrine of the Two Faces of War.
15. Ji Yong is present wherever force is used reluctantly to protect.
16. Ji Song is present wherever force becomes appetite.
17. Both can inhabit the same battle.
18. Both can inhabit the same person.
19. The Jillow contains both faces, but the faithful are not therefore excused from choosing which face they strengthen.
20. Even the baboons were subject to karma.
21. This caused another question.
22. Did each baboon eventually spin the Wheel?
23. Ji said yes.
24. Tim asked how.

VII. Bako's Choice

1. During one campaign, Bako and his troop came upon a village caught between armed men and families attempting to flee.
2. The baboons had a clear line of fire.
3. They also had no clear way to fire without risking the people they meant to protect.
4. Ji Song urged destruction.
5. Not in words, for Ji Song rarely requires words.
6. There is a part of every creature that sees an enemy and wishes for the simplest possible answer.
7. Bako raised the bazooka.
8. Then lowered it.
9. The younger baboons watched.
10. Bako chose the harder action.
11. They moved unseen through the village.
12. They created noises in empty streets.
13. They knocked weapons from unattended places.
14. They opened routes where none appeared open.
15. They frightened armed men with the deeply unsettling experience of being struck by something they could not see.
16. Slowly the families escaped.
17. Only when the last civilians had gone did Bako permit the bazookas to speak.
18. The rabbis say that this was the moment the Invisible Army became more than a joke in sacred history.
19. Power had been available.
20. Restraint had been harder.
21. Bako chose restraint first.
22. His odds upon the Wheel improved.
23. By how much is unknown.
24. Tim requested a number.

VIII. The Prophet and the General

1. Bako returned eventually to New York.
2. Years passed.
3. Ji Yong Ni was born in 2003, several years after the world had incorrectly expected catastrophe from Y2K.
4. According to Baji'i teaching, the timing was not an error so much as divine scheduling.
5. Greta Stark has expressed sympathy for the difficulty of divine scheduling.
6. When Ji reached the age at which the Divine Connection began revealing the hidden things of Baji'ism, the rabbis tell of a dream.
7. In the dream Ji stood in a New York subway station after midnight.
8. The platform was empty.
9. Then something sat beside him.
10. The bench creaked.
11. Ji looked over and saw nothing.
12. 'Bako?' he asked.
13. The invisible baboon made a sound.
14. Ji somehow understood.
15. Bako did not kneel.
16. Ji was pleased by this because kneeling would have been weird.
17. The old general asked no blessing.
18. He asked only whether the war had mattered.
19. Ji did not answer immediately.
20. Then he said, 'Did you help people?'
21. Bako indicated yes.
22. 'Then probably.'
23. It was not a grand revelation.
24. Bako did not need one.

IX. The Unseen Good

1. The Invisible Army became, in later Baji'ism, a symbol for acts that leave little evidence of who performed them.
2. Not all goodness is witnessed.
3. Not all courage receives a photograph.
4. Not every person who helps another becomes known for helping.
5. The baboons were literally invisible, which made the metaphor unusually easy.
6. Amanda Haeberlin taught that doing right only when somebody is watching is merely performance with better branding.
7. She taught this loudly.
8. Gretta taught that responsibility still counts when nobody congratulates you for it.
9. Tim observed that anonymous good deeds should still affect karma.
10. Ji agreed.
11. Evan asked whether anonymous bad deeds also counted.
12. Ji said obviously.
13. This disappointed hypothetical criminals.
14. The Wheel, unlike human beings, is difficult to impress and impossible to fool.
15. The baboons did not fight for statues.
16. Statues of invisible baboons would have been conceptually difficult anyway.
17. They fought, when they fought rightly, because someone needed help.
18. This became the Teaching of the Unseen Good:
19. An act does not become righteous because it is noticed.
20. It becomes righteous because of what it does.

X. The Army That Was Never Seen

1. There are people who say the Invisible Baboons never existed.
2. Their evidence is substantial.
3. No photograph clearly shows one.
4. No military archive records Bako.
5. No New York census contains a category for invisible primates with anti-armor capabilities.
6. Baji'ism acknowledges these difficulties.
7. It is not especially troubled by them.
8. A religion whose supreme deity is a two-sided pillow has already made certain methodological commitments.
9. The question is not merely whether Bako can be proven.
10. The question is why the story survived.
11. It survived because the Jillow has two faces and so does power.
12. It survived because fighting evil does not automatically make every action good.
13. It survived because restraint can require more strength than destruction.
14. It survived because unseen acts still shape the world.
15. And it survived because invisible baboons with bazookas are extremely difficult to forget once the Divine Connection has revealed them.
16. Ji, when asked for his final theological assessment of the army, considered the matter.
17. 'They're cool,' he said.
18. Tim asked whether that was all.
19. Ji said yes.
20. AJ suggested that future rabbis could elaborate.
21. This was precisely what happened.
22. Somewhere, perhaps beneath New York, an invisible troop still waits.
23. Their weapons are maintained.
24. Their existence is disputed.

Scribal Note

The established Baji'i source states that invisible bazooka-wielding baboons are based in New York and fight against the Taliban. Ji Yong Ni, as the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth, is the source through whom this hidden army was revealed to Baji'ism. Those points are treated here as canon. Bako, the army's origins, its campaigns, Ji's dream, and the theological doctrines surrounding force, restraint, and unseen goodness are narrative expansions created for this gospel. The story intentionally uses the companions sparingly and preserves the Floriculture national championship, Marcia Ann Humphreys, the Holy Land reclamation, and the wider company of prophets for later installments.